How Justin Waller Went From Digging Ditches to Starting a Steel Company

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📋 Executive Summary

Justin Waller graduated in 2009 into a jobless recession, dug ditches, aggressively pursued a construction boss until hired, then auto-drafted nearly his entire paycheck for 6 months to save the $10K Louisiana requires for a contractor's license—launching a steel company now 14 years old.

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📚 The Book That Sparked the Idea 0:00

- Justin read *Rich Dad Poor Dad* and it planted the idea of owning a business
  - He is dyslexic and had to read the book twice to get through it
  - After reading it, he *knew* he wanted a business — but hadn't yet figured out what form that would take
- His original plan was conventional: graduate in construction management, move to Dallas, get a salaried job
  - That plan never materialized

🎓 Graduating Into the 2009 Recession 0:00

- Graduated in **2009** — the depth of the financial crisis — and found there were essentially no jobs available
- Ended up taking a labor job digging ditches for a company called **Austin Bridge and Road**
  - This was before he returned to Baton Rouge, Louisiana
  - A humbling entry point for someone with a construction management degree

🚪 Relentlessly Pursuing the Boss 0:21

- Justin kept showing up to a hospital construction job site repeatedly, trying to get a meeting with the boss

- The boss finally agreed to see him — Justin expected to be thrown out
  - Instead, the boss leaned back in his chair and said: *"Bro, I love this shit."*
  - He gave Justin a job on the spot
- The takeaway: persistent, in-person hustle got him through the door where applications would not have

💰 The Savings Strategy That Made It Happen 0:21

- Once employed, Justin was earning **$60,000 a year**
- He set up an auto-draft of **80–90% of every paycheck** directly out of his account
  - "I never saw it" — the money was gone before he could spend it
  - Removing the money from sight eliminated the temptation to spend it
- Over **6 months** he accumulated the required savings

📋 Getting the Contractor's License 0:45

- In Louisiana, obtaining a contractor's license requires a **minimum net worth of $10,000**
  - Justin did not have this when he started — it was the specific barrier he had to clear
- After 6 months of aggressive saving, he went to the bank, confirmed the funds, and applied for his contractor's license
- That license became the legal foundation for his steel company
- As of the interview, the business has been running for **nearly 14 years** (14 years in March)

> The entire arc — book → recession → ditch-digging → relentless hustle → forced savings → license — shows a repeatable pattern: identify the one concrete barrier ($10K net worth), reverse-engineer a brutal savings rate to clear it, and execute.